persistent skepticism highlights the challenges of navigating populist pressures within multilateral organizations.

8.5 UN Peacekeeping and Trump

UN peacekeeping operations, primarily managed by international political and security elites, have long relied on substantial financial backing from the United States. As the largest contributor to the UN peacekeeping budget, the United States was responsible for 27 percent of its funding in 2023, though a congressional cap formally limited contributions to 25 percent.[48] Beyond mandatory contributions, the United States also provides voluntary funding for specific programs, as well as critical training and logistical support. This dominance over financial support and expertise drew sharp criticism from Donald Trump, whose disdain for IOs made the UN a frequent target during his first presidency.

Trump especially rejected the authority of the UN's bureaucratic elites, favoring unilateral American leadership in conflicts such as Israel–Palestine and Kosovo–Serbia (Landau and Lehrs 2022). His administration dismissed prior UN resolutions as ineffective and largely disregarded the organization's role in these disputes. Trump's critiques extended to peacekeeping itself, as he threatened to defund its operations and demanded that the United States contribute significantly less to the UN's coffers.

UN secretary general António Guterres sought to mitigate these tensions through a combination of appeasement, reform, and strategic diplomacy. Recognizing Trump's aversion to bureaucracy, Guterres reframed the UN's mission, emphasizing a "leaner, more efficient" institution that aligned with Trump's priorities.[49] He initiated structural reforms, such as opening the recruitment system to outsiders, consolidating departments into the streamlined Department of Peace Operations, and granting regional offices greater autonomy.[50] Under US pressure, the UN General Assembly cut $600 million from the peacekeeping budget in 2017—a concession that signaled responsiveness to Trump's fiscal demands.[51]

While Guterres publicly acknowledged Trump's criticisms, he also worked to sideline the administration's influence in key areas. He cultivated strong alliances with European and Latin American member states,[52] which allowed him to bypass internal pressures and focus on broader global